

One Letter That Changed Everything

A SHORT STORY

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I folded the letter along its original creases and drove three hundred miles. The town had no gate. It had a diner, a post office, and a house with a fallen oak. I knocked. An old woman opened the door, her face a map of my mother's future. She squinted. "You look like her," she said. "The sister who left." I handed over the letter. She read it, then touched my wrist. "She died last spring," I said. The woman nodded. "I know. I was writing to you." I looked down at my hands--the same knuckles, the same veins. The letter wasn't a message. It was a mirror. And the thing that changed was not the past, but the simple, terrible knowledge that I had been addressed all along.